

# Xudong Zhu

Ph.D. Candidate in International History, University of Aberdeen

[xudong.zhu01@gmail.com](mailto:xudong.zhu01@gmail.com) | [xudong-zhu01.github.io](https://github.com/xudong-zhu01)

---

## RESEARCH INTERESTS

International history of great-power strategy and the global order; Sino-European and Sino-American relations from the interwar period to the present; theories of empire and international order; applied history and contemporary grand strategy.

---

## EDUCATION

### University of Aberdeen

Aberdeen, UK

*Ph.D. Candidate in International History*

Mar. 2025 – Present

- Dissertation: *Weapons, Warlords, and Order: Strategic Cooperation Between China and Germany in a Time of Global Transition (1928–1938)*.
- Supervisors: Prof. Dr. Thomas Weber; Dr. Andrew Dilley.
- Fields: applied history, grand strategy, global security.

### Ruprecht-Karls-Universität Heidelberg

Heidelberg, Germany

*M.A. in American Studies (Political Science and History track)*

Oct. 2021 – Aug. 2023

- Thesis: *On the Theory of Empire in International Relations and an Analysis of Pax Americana*.
- Coursework included U.S. economic policy, the Transatlantic alliance, nuclear deterrence theory, political psychology, and varieties of American conservatism.

### Jilin University

Changchun, China

*LL.B. in Diplomacy*

Sep. 2017 – Jun. 2021

- Coursework included international history, international-relations theory, international law, power politics, and political philosophy.

---

## PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

- Royal Historical Society — Postgraduate Member (2025–).
- Association of Chinese Political Studies — Member (2025–).

---

## PUBLICATIONS

### Peer-Reviewed Book Chapter

- Wang, L., and Zhu, X. “How to Maintain a Balance in the Intricate *Pas de Trois* among China, US and EU.” In *The Trilateral Interactions: China, the US, and the EU on Tensions, Competition, and Cooperation*, edited by Zuokui Liu, Marek Hrubec, and Shaohua Yan. London: Routledge, 2026. doi:10.4324/9781003736554-8.

### Conference Papers

- Zhu, X. “Beyond Divide and Rule: Advocating a Respect-Based Chinese Policy Toward the European Union.” Annual Conference of the Association of Chinese Political Studies (ACPS), 20 November 2025. [<https://abdn.elsevierpure.com/en/publications/ff9b30a6-1b2b-40b0-bc3b-2ef41e4d4234>].
- Zhu, X. “What to Do About the Strategic Challenge? An Analysis of the Background of NATO’s New China Strategy.” Seventh Annual Young Scholars Forum on U.S.–China Relations, The Carter Center, 2022.

### Prize Essay

- Zhu, X. “Trump as the (In)advertent Harbinger of a New Transatlantic Security Architecture: Europe’s Autonomy as a Bulwark Against Chinese Influence.” **Runner-up, Jimmy Carter Prize**, China Focus Essay Contest, 2025. [<https://uscnpm.org/2025/08/12/europe-autonomy-against-chinese-influence/>].

### Public Scholarship and Commentary

*Contributing Writer*, U.S.–China Perception Monitor (The Carter Center), published in Chinese:

- “Towards Europe’s Strongest Conventional Armed Force: An Outline of *Gesamtkonzeption der militärischen Verteidigung*.” 30 April 2026. [<https://zmyx.info/german-national-defense-strategy/>].
- “If Bismarck Ran Washington: What Approach Would He Take to U.S.–China Relations?” 11 December 2025. [<https://zmyx.info/if-bismarck-directed-china-policy-in-washington/>].
- “From ‘The Art of the Deal’ to ‘The Art of Diplomacy’: The Continuities in Trump’s View of Interna-

tional Relations.” 11 September 2025. [<https://zmyx.info/on-trump-interview-with-playboy-in-1990/>].

---

## TEACHING EXPERIENCE

### University of Aberdeen

Aberdeen, UK

*Teaching Assistant*

2025/26

- HI1022 *Europe in the Twentieth Century*.
- HI2520 *Global Empire in the Long Nineteenth Century*.

### Ruprecht-Karls-Universität Heidelberg

Heidelberg, Germany

*Tutor*

Summer Semester 2023

- *From Washington to Peking: A History of Early Interactions Between the U.S. and China*: led seminar discussions on Sino-American relations (1784–1882), covering trade, diplomacy, and labour migration, with attention to China’s integration into the nineteenth-century international order.

---

## DIGITAL HUMANITIES PROJECTS

### bisimAI: A Bismarck-Persona Fine-Tune of Gemma 4 E4B

2026

*Sole author* | [huggingface.co/Ottomin/bisimAI](https://huggingface.co/Ottomin/bisimAI)

- LoRA fine-tune of Google’s Gemma 4 E4B Instruct base model (~7B parameters), trained to adopt the rhetorical and strategic voice of Otto von Bismarck for historical-persona research and teaching.

---

## PROFESSIONAL AND RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

### University of Aberdeen — Experience, Engagement & Wellbeing Team

Aberdeen, UK

*Research Intern*

Jun. 2025 – Aug. 2025

- Conducted qualitative research on the study journeys of international students (undergraduate, postgraduate-taught, and ISC/Language Centre cohorts); produced strategy roadmaps to enhance the student experience.
- Coordinated communication across academic and professional-services departments and contributed to orientation materials for incoming international students.

### The Carter Center — U.S.–China Perception Monitor

Atlanta, USA (Remote)

*Academic Assistant*

Jun. 2020 – Sep. 2020

- Translated and edited articles on U.S.–China relations for the centre’s bilingual platform.
- Co-organised eight academic conferences and authored proceedings summaries.
- Conducted interviews with policy scholars and authored articles averaging over 5,000 readers.

*Earlier research experience:* University of Tübingen — “International and European Studies” programme (2019); Rutgers, The State University of New Jersey — summer programme (2018); Jilin University — Field study along the China-North Korea border regarding National Security and Border Control (2017).

---

## LANGUAGES

Chinese (native), English (proficient), German (proficient).

---

## AWARDS

- **Runner-up, Jimmy Carter Prize**, China Focus Essay Contest (2025)
- **Excellence Award**, 16th National Diplomatic Etiquette Competition (2018).
- **Best Negotiator**, 3rd Simulated Diplomatic Negotiation Competition, Jilin University (2018).
- **Diplomatic Award**, 1st Simulated Diplomatic Spokesperson Competition, Jilin University (2017).

---

## RESEARCH AND TECHNICAL SKILLS

- **Primary-source research:** archival and documentary research in Chinese, English, and German across diplomatic, military, and political collections.
- **Machine learning and large language models:** fine-tuning of LLMs using LoRA, QLoRA, and supervised fine-tuning (SFT); design and deployment of retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) pipelines.
- **Quantitative methods:** descriptive and inferential statistical analysis in Python, R and SPSS.
- **Document preparation:** L<sup>A</sup>T<sub>E</sub>X and Markdown for academic writing and typesetting.

---

## SERVICE

- Moderator, Academic Forum at the School of International and Public Affairs (SIPA), Jilin University.
- Research assistant to Prof. Swaran Singh (Jawaharlal Nehru University) during his visit to Jilin University.